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2026 NAIROBI ONSITE · TALK + WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Measuring agency in the context of AI tools

As social services develop AI tools, how can we tell when AI tool use is expanding or undermining human agency? What is agency? Why should we measure it? How can we measure it to know whether AI tools are actually supporting it?

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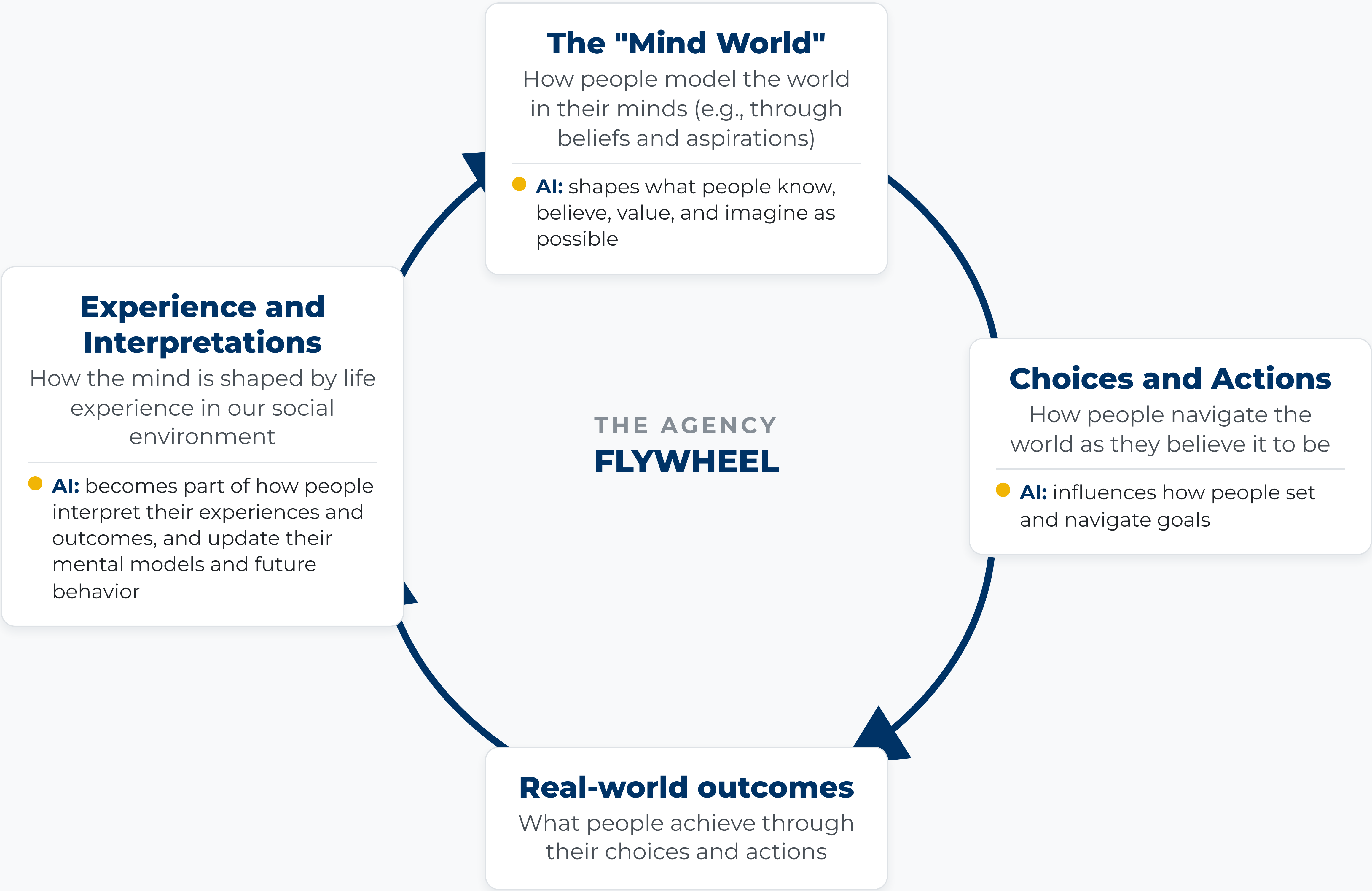
THE AGENCY FLYWHEEL

Our worldview of agency in a flywheel



The loop turns both ways

When it turns well, capable choices bring results that promote a positive cycle. When it turns badly, failed choices result in a negative cycle.

AI products sit inside it, at every point

An AI tool can push any of the four elements in either direction, while generating lots of digital behavioral traces.

So measuring agency in the context of an AI tool means **understanding these digital traces**, **connecting them with real-world outcomes**, and **monitoring what the loop does wherever the AI tool meets it**.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS · THREE STUDIES, 2025 TO 2026

AI can expand agency, and it can hamper it

CAN EXPAND THE FULL FINDING

People stay with tools that **make them feel more capable**, even when the tools make mistakes. AI can strengthen agency in five ways: instrumental, cognitive, affective, relational, and structural.

FLIP BACK

CAN HAMPER THE FULL FINDING

A ChatGPT-style math tutor boosted practice scores by 48%, but students scored **17% below the control group** once the AI was removed. A guardrailed tutor that offered hints rather than solutions eliminated the harm, yet students using either tool remained unaware of the gap between feeling supported and actually learning.

FLIP BACK

CAN HAMPER THE FULL FINDING

Across 1,372 participants, an accurate chatbot raised reasoning accuracy by 25 percentage points, but a faulty one drove it 15 points below unaided performance. People followed wrong AI advice on **roughly four in five consulted trials** and became more confident even when misled; time pressure, incentives, and feedback reduced but did not eliminate the effect.

FLIP BACK

In all three studies, people looked engaged and felt capable while it happened. Usage and satisfaction cannot tell expansion of agency from its erosion, which is why we measure agency directly.

Sources: How AI Is Affecting Human Agency (Jigsaw, July 2025) · Generative AI without guardrails can harm learning (PNAS 122(26), 2025) · Thinking, Fast, Slow, and Artificial: the rise of cognitive surrender (Wharton working paper, 2026).

In a typical research study where agency is explictly in the theory of change...

Theories can be used to define agency.

In these studies, you usually strive to get full observability on the agentic process and design the program in a way to produce these signals of agency. For example, in **social cognitive theory**, people are agents who intentionally shape their circumstances. Agency has four core elements in this framework:

1 · Intentionality

EXAMPLE · GOAL COMMITMENT

The learner states a business goal in her own words and **commits to a concrete next step** before the session ends.

FLIP BACK

2 · Forethought

EXAMPLE · PLANNING AND TRADEOFFS

She **weighs two ideas against each other**, asking what each would cost, earn, and risk in her local market.

FLIP BACK

3 · Self-reactiveness

EXAMPLE · COURSE CORRECTION

She returns with progress updates and **revises the plan** when the first supplier falls through, instead of abandoning the goal.

FLIP BACK

4 · Self-reflectiveness

EXAMPLE · CALIBRATED SELF-BELIEF

After the business pitch, she reviews what worked and what did not, and updates her **mental models to develop the business plan**.

FLIP BACK

Source: Bandura (2001), Social cognitive theory: an agentic perspective.

But in the context of NGOs iteratively developing AI tools where agency may or may not be central to the theory of change...

What you need to measure also depends on the forms of agency and how agency manifests in your product.

	Agency with respect to the end goals	Agency with respect to the AI tool
	Can users make progress toward outcomes they value, whether through, around, or beyond the tool?	Can users understand, question, adapt, and control the tool, deciding when and how to rely on it?
Internally experienced agency People's thoughts and feelings	ON-PLATFORM DATA · IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY Short in-app surveys probing users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time (e.g., How confident is the user about developing a successful business idea? How much control do they feel over reaching their ultimate goal?) OFF-PLATFORM DATA · PHONE OR IN-PERSON SURVEY Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that **systematically** probe users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time. FLIP BACK	ON-PLATFORM DATA · IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY Short in-app surveys probing whether users felt able to understand, question, or adopt an AI mentor's advice. OFF-PLATFORM DATA · VALIDATED SCALES Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that systematically probe users' trust in AI and perceived dependence versus empowerment when using a tool. FLIP BACK
Externally expressed agency People's choices and actions	ON-PLATFORM DATA · CONVERSATION LOGS Longitudinal user signals of agency in AI conversation logs, especially those related to setting and navigating longer-term goals or demonstrating resilience despite difficulties. OFF-PLATFORM DATA · RUBRIC-RATED PITCHES Longer phone/in-person surveys tracking how users develop their business ideas; rubric-rated observations of ideas and pitches; or classroom observation of team framework, ideally linked to downstream outcomes like business earnings. FLIP BACK	ON-PLATFORM DATA · DIGITAL TRACES Digital traces (e.g., interaction patterns or conversation logs) showing whether users understand, question, or adopt an AI mentor's advice. OFF-PLATFORM DATA · OBSERVATION AND INTERVIEWS Observation or interview data (e.g., usability studies) on tool usage for developing business ideas. FLIP BACK

Agency measurement sits at Level 3

LEVEL 1
Models Evaluation
Does the AI system perform as intended?

→

LEVEL 2
Product Evaluation
Does the overall product engage and retain users?

→

LEVEL 3
User Evaluation
Does the product change users' thoughts, feelings, knowledge and behaviour towards the development outcome?

→

LEVEL 4
Impact Evaluation
Do users with access to the product improve development outcomes?

Nobody can run an RCT on every product change. **Validated agency measures at Level 3** move when the product changes, and they speak to what Level 4 cares about. That is what lets teams anchor their A/B tests on something that matters.

HOW WE SUGGEST YOU DO IT · THREE STEPS THAT LOOP

Teams should specify what agency means for their specific users and contexts

1

Define agency for your local problem

What kind of agency is the tool supposed to support? **For whom? To what end?** Anchor the definition in your program's theory of change.

2

Measure with the right tools, on the right data, at the right moment

Combine **on-platform** signals, such as in-app surveys and digital traces, with **off-platform** surveys, interviews, observations, and records.

3

Test and validate your measurement tools iteratively

Check **reliability and validity** for your context, and compare LLM-based measures against a human-coded gold standard.

Iterate: agency shifts across time and settings, so keep refining how you define and measure it

PART 2 · WORKSHOP

Can you identify signals of agency in human-AI conversations?

In this workshop, we focus on a specific agency measurement in the quadrant of **Externally expressed agency x Agency with respect to the end goals** (Do they act toward their goal?), which is especially relevant to AI tools. We aim to examine **human-AI conversations** in different domains, which can hold **rich signals of agency**. You will read **10 synthetic conversations** from one of the **three example domains**, answer **four questions and an open note**, and compare your labels with an **AI judge** at the end.

ACTIVITY · ~ 60 MINUTES

Work in pairs and identify signals of agency in synthetic human-AI conversations

1 **Claim your link in the shared sheet**

Scan the QR below, or type the sheet link. In your table's domain block, put your name next to the lowest unclaimed code — that row's link is yours.

2 **Open the link on your phone or laptop**

You will see ten conversations between users and a fictional AI product, plus the four coding questions.

3 **Work in pairs to discuss the coding for about 40 minutes**

Answer the four questions for each conversation and leave one open note. No worries if you can't finish all ten.

4 **Then discuss learnings at your table for about 15 minutes**

Find one conversation where you disagreed. Argue it out: what evidence did each of you use? Nominate your hardest case to code.

Open the claim sheet — scan or type

docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1EFiydj01k9RCmOiisyRJLZysTd5DGBamqnsMPQDrGUQ

One link per person. **Everyone sees the sheet live** — a row with a name on it is taken.

THREE SETS OF SYNTHETIC CONVERSATIONS BASED ON AI PRODUCTS OUR GRANTEES DEVELOPED

AI educational mentor
Business-idea coaching inside a school entrepreneurship program

AI health assistant
Post-visit follow-up line for clinic patients

AI agricultural advisor
Crop, weather and market Q&A for smallholder farmers

KEEP THIS SLIDE UP WHILE YOU CODE · FRAMEWORK: THE AGENCY FLYWHEEL, ONE QUESTION PER NODE

Think about four questions & open codes

1 BELIEFS AND ASPIRATIONS

Belief or aspiration shift

Does the user express a new or changed sense of what is possible for them?

2 PURPOSEFUL ACTION AND CHOICES

Specific action or decision

Does the user state a specific action or decision they will take, or have already taken?

3 REAL-WORLD OUTCOMES

Links action to a life outcome

Does the user connect the actions or advice to a real-life outcome they care about: income, harvest, health, school fees?

4 INTERPRETED EXPERIENCE

Uses past experience

Does the user refer to a past success or failure and use it to inform what they do now?

OPEN NOTE Anything else you notice, especially the agency loop turning backwards: e.g., growing discouragement, over-reliance, decisions handed to the AI. Short conversations with nothing to code are normal.

ANSWERS **Yes** **No** Think abou the following four questions in a top-down manner, and then use the open note for describe labels not captured by the questions in a bottom-up manner.

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PART 2 · WORKSHOP CLOCK

40:00

READY

SET 5 min 15 min 40 min −1 min +1 min Start Reset

DEBRIEF · LIVE IN CALIBRATE

Over to Calibrate: how well did we align?

1

People vs. people

How often did we give the same answer to the same conversation?

2

AI vs. people

An AI coded the same conversations with your exact rubric. Does it align with the room?

The point of the exercise is that once a rubric earns agreement between people, an AI can apply it consistently across thousands of conversations. That is what makes agency measurement scale.

Agency measurement is complex. Try out these public tools to learn more.

The blog →
Measuring Agency in a Digital Context, by The Agency Fund and Google Jigsaw

The Claude skill →
ask-agency-measurement: a coach that turns these frameworks into a plan for your product

The NotebookLM →
Curated papers and validated agency scales you can interrogate conversationally

The evaluation playbook →
The full four-level framework for evaluating GenAI products, level by level

For questions on these tools, contact zezhen@agency.fund.